

(AI)nfluencer

INFLUENCER MARKETING IS NO DOUBT A MASSIVE PHENOMENON. Many brands and marketing agencies heavily rely on influencer marketing to get the word out to the right folks in the most impactful way. More than advertisements on old school mediums such as outdoor banners, TV ads and even some of the newer targeted advertisements, influencer marketing has a much better chance of converting the viewers into prospective customers. Influencers have an established audience and more importantly, they are capable of reading the room and changing tactics midway through the pitch. Live Streaming is one such medium wherein regulation is a bit difficult. On platforms such as Instagram and Twitch, the streams are no longer available after the stream is over, unless they chose to save it. This circumvents the filters that are put in place and if there isn't anyone reporting the streaming, then the influencers can get away with making all sorts of claims.

Thankfully, the law is catching up. Depending on which laws are broken, the offences committed do fall within the ambit of traditional regulatory agencies. The crypto scams caught the attention of the financial regulators and even entire governments. Advertising regulators in several countries have started implementing measures to make advertisements by influencers more transparent with proper declaration that's clearly visible. Even platforms have built-in options for content creators to declare if a content piece has promotional content. Folks peddling unproven remedies during the covid epidemic had a little warning message shown alongside their videos and tweets on several popular social media platforms. A more recent incident would be that of several influencers banding together and leveraging their massive communities to manipulate stocks to net gains of about 114 million US dollars. The US Securities and Exchange Commission has gone after these influencers in the same manner as they do when major banks and investment firms try to play dirty with the stock market.

What remains to be seen is whether influencer marketing loses its efficacy with more and more regulations in play. When the scales are balanced and this new medium of advertising has the same set of checks and balances

as other mediums, will it continue to have the same lead over other forms of advertising that it enjoys right now? I'm all for free speech but not at the cost of taking advantage of the viewers or the readers, a lot of whom blindly trust the influencers that they follow.

With the advent of live speech-to-text captioning and real time image processing technologies that can capture text within individual frames within a video, it's becoming easier for platforms to have automated takedown mechanisms. But automated takedown mechanisms can also be misused by the platforms to censor certain content. There's always two sides to every argument and in this case, the possibility of censorship shouldn't be used to prevent regulatory mechanisms from being implemented. We're just hearing of the Twitter Files wherein alleged attempts to side with one political party in the US are coming to light. And that's primarily because the ownership of the company changes hands. Who knows how deep the rabbit hole goes and how many other platforms are allegedly engaging in similar behaviour?

What would be even more interesting is when AI based tools add a whole new dimension to this phenomenon. Everyone is giving ChatGPT a go and the tool, with the right prompts, can come with some really surprising output. If an influencer were to leverage AI based tools then they could easily come up with a really effective script. Feeding audience metrics to AI-powered tools will net you insights on how to most effectively target the right audience. So you could get a really well-written advertising campaign to the right audience. And these tools can be used by anyone who's willing to pay. In a way, it becomes an equaliser of sorts. Would influencers continue to be the most effective marketing medium once that happens? 



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